NO. 151 · SINGAPORE

THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.

MONDAY 2 NOVEMBER 2026



PRICE AVAILABLE UPON REQUEST. FOUR OUTLETS PRINTED FOUR DIFFERENT ONES (P10)

THE WORLD

Iran cuts its Hormuz reopening timetable from seven days to two, and Qatar's own gas carrier is struck

TECHNOLOGY

Meta and Microsoft raised sixty-two and a half billion dollars in a day, for "general corporate purposes"

THE LONG READ

Taiwan beat fraud, and 124,617 of its citizens lost internet banking for five years

Source: Glashütte Original Senator Aventurine Art Déco Blue, maker's launch photography, via Gear Patrol, 29 October 2026.

THIS ISSUE · NO. 151

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THE UNSTATED NUMBER. It kept turning up. A watch launched without a price, and four printed instead (p10). Sixty-two and a half billion dollars raised for a purpose no prospectus names (p7). A trillion-parameter model with no published file size (p8). A display sold on its contrast and not its resolution (p9). An anxiety effect that never once cleared zero (p12). And a register of citizens that one legislator has counted, once (p21).

FROM THE DESK

"Omne ignotum pro magnifico est." — everything unknown is taken for magnificent.

Tacitus, *Agricola*, chapter 30, in the speech he gives to Calgacus, about AD 98[1]

Tacitus meant an unseen enemy. He could have meant a blank in a prospectus, which the market reads as a bigger number than any figure would have been (p7).

THE STRIP · AT FRIDAY'S CLOSE

US 10-year[2]	4.94%	▼ 4bp
US 10-year real[2]	2.60%	▼ 3bp
10-yr breakeven	2.34%	desk's own
Brent[3]	$113.43	▲ 2.37%
Gold spot	$3,876	flat o/wknd
Bitcoin	$77,860	▲ 0.6%
Ether	$2,262	▲ 0.5%
USD/SGD	1.2784	ECB ref
USD/JPY	157.25	ECB ref

Brent rose 13 per cent across October while the ten-year inflation breakeven narrowed (p4). Gold and the two crypto levels are Sunday-evening Singapore prices, not exchange closes. Not advice.[2]

FROM THE ARCHIVE · NO. 133, AND THE RULE IT MADE

A Monday evergreen, since the Index runs Fridays and the Scoreboard Saturdays. Eighteen issues ago a reader read the headlines back to this desk and called them what they were: click-bait, not the headlines of a news source.[4]

The examples were exact. "The ministry called it a limited fire." "The hotel licenses the name. A Las Vegas firm fills it." Sixteen of seventeen headlines in that issue withheld the thing they were about.

The cause was a previous fix. A style rule had cut headlines to fourteen words; shortness turned them into riddles. The repair was to require that a headline name its subject and state what it did, in the active voice, with the dek carrying a name and a number.

Which is why this issue's headlines read as they do — and why an edition about blanks has to be especially careful not to leave one in its own first line.

SOURCES 1 Tacitus, *Agricola*, chapter 30, in the speech attributed to the Caledonian leader Calgacus; the Latin phrase is his, the English gloss is the standard rendering. 2 Levels at Friday 30 October's close, each sourced instrument by instrument on p14, where the United States Treasury's own daily par and real yield curves supply both yield lines and this desk's arithmetic supplies the breakeven. **Gold and the two crypto figures are Sunday-evening daily-series levels, not exchange closes; the London bullion benchmark's own price file is licence-gated and refused this desk.** Foreign exchange is the European Central Bank's published reference rate for 30 October. 3 Brent's close and its October change from Trading Economics, read at source; the October move is discussed on p4. 4 This magazine's own Issue Log and brand specification, Nos. 133 and 134.

THE WORLD · HORMUZ AND DOHA

Araghchi cuts Iran's Hormuz reopening timeline from seven days to two

Qatar's own gas carrier Al Mayeda was struck on 30 October, hours before its government's third day of mediation; Washington has told Gulf allies to expect strikes as early as 4 November.

Iran's foreign minister, **Abbas Araghchi**, said on **Sunday 1 November** that Tehran's timetable for partially reopening the Strait of Hormuz had fallen from **seven days to two** — the first movement on a number Iran has held since the blockade began. His conditions did not move: lift the naval blockade, restore the June oil waivers, unfreeze assets abroad, thin the American military presence, recognise an Iran–Oman arrangement over the strait, and stop the fighting on every front.[1]

Two days is the concession. Everything around it got worse. On **Friday 30 October** a tanker caught fire about **25 nautical miles** north-east of Khasab after a small boat came alongside and **attached two explosive devices to its hull**. That evening the Qatari gas carrier *Al Mayeda* was hit by what its owners called unidentified objects. Qatar is the mediator; its own ship was struck while its officials were in the room.[2]

On **31 October** a projectile strike on a gas vessel **40 nautical miles** south of Lavan Island was logged by the British naval reporting centre, and the Revolutionary Guard's navy escalated a claim from two to **four** tankers struck by mines — **claims the American central command disputes**, having said it cleared the lanes of mines and that ships were being hit by projectiles. No vessel is named in any of the four.[3]

And on **1 November** Tehran designated Britain's Royal Navy, Royal Air Force and Secret Intelligence Service **"terrorist and hostile"** entities, for making British territory available to the war. Three Gulf officials told an American broadcaster that Washington had warned allies to prepare for strikes **as early as 4 November** — the day after the midterms. **That date rests on anonymous officials and a White House "we do not comment".**[4]

DOHA — QATAR MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

After its carrier was hit, the mediator's own ministry issued **"strong condemnation and denunciation of the attack"**, called it **"a dangerous act that threatens the safety of maritime navigation and the security of global energy supplies"**, and said Qatar **"reserves its right to take all necessary measures"** to protect its interests. The most under-read line of the week.[2]

THE CHATTER · WHAT ANALYSTS SAY ABOUT ARAGHCHI'S TWO DAYS

Hamidreza Azizi of Crisis Group, to Al Jazeera on 1 November: "*diplomacy and military preparations are proceeding simultaneously.*" **Negar Mortazavi** of the Center for International Policy: "*Each side wants the other to act first.*" **Andreas Krieg** of King's College London names the asymmetry: Iran may become willing to compromise just as Washington becomes willing to strike. **Mohsen Rezaei**, on the letter from the American vice-president: "*I read the letter… Their tone has completely changed*" — a good sign, he said, while refusing any reopening until the demands are met.[5]

THE SCEPTIC · HORMUZ IS A FREIGHT SHOCK, NOT A BARRELS SHOCK

The framing to resist is that the strait is shut and the oil is gone. October crude exports through Hormuz averaged about **11.1m barrels a day — some 2 per cent below September**, and flows are **up more than 70 per cent since July** under the convoy system. **Mary Melton** of the London shipbroker Braemar told CNBC on 30 October the supply effect was not "*a massive impact*"; what bites is freight. Supertanker hire went from about **US$249,000 a day** in early September to **over US$900,000**, freight from **US$6.50 to US$21 a barrel**, with **a fifth of the world supertanker fleet** tied up in the shuttle. The price pays for tonnage and risk, not for absent oil. **Dated falsifier:** if a week's loadings fall below six million barrels a day, this is a barrels shock after all.[6]

Brent closed Friday at **US$113.43**, up 2.37 per cent and **13 per cent across October**, having traded above US$117 — and still below the **US$118.35** March wartime closing high.[6]

SOURCES 1 Al Jazeera, "Iran and US explore diplomacy amid rising threats of war", 1 November 2026, read at source; Araghchi via IRNA. 2 Al Jazeera on the Qatari carrier, 1 November, read at source, carrying the Qatari ministry's statement; Oilprice.com, 30 October, for the Khasab fire and the UK Maritime Trade Operations account. 3 Al Jazeera, 1 November; Gulf News live coverage, 1 November. **The mine claims are Iranian claims that American central command disputes; unverified, no vessel named.** 4 Xinhua, Tehran dateline, 1 November; Times of Israel, 31 October, relaying MSNOW's three Gulf officials — **single-sourced to anonymous officials.** 5 Dawn, 30 October 2026. 6 Al Jazeera and Times of Israel, 31 October to 1 November. 7 CNBC, 30 October 2026, for the flow, freight and hire figures and both analysts; Brent from Trading Economics.

AROUND THE DESKS · THE MARKET'S VERDICT

Gold fell 3.6 per cent to a 13-month low as Hormuz burned

The ten-year inflation compensation narrowed from 2.38 to 2.34 per cent across 28 to 30 October — the opposite of what an oil-driven inflation shock looks like.

While tankers burned last week and Brent rose **13 per cent across October**, two prices that are supposed to rise in a war fell. Gold fell **3.62 per cent in a single day** to a **thirteen-month low**. And the gap between what American government bonds pay and what inflation-protected ones pay — the market's own forecast of inflation over the next decade — **narrowed**, from **2.38 per cent on 28 October to 2.34 on the 30th.**[1]

That is a judgement, not an accident. A market expecting a Gulf war to push prices up for years would widen that gap, not shrink it; a market frightened of the war would buy gold. It did neither. On its own prices, last week was dangerous for ships and not for the price level — which is what the shipping figures say (p3).[1]

A bank has priced the disagreement. JPMorgan's model puts Brent's fair value at **US$94** against a market near **US$114**, and finds **no evidence freight explains the gap** — roughly **US$20** of pure risk premium. Stretches more than 5 per cent above fair value have historically lasted about **3.8 months**. Its implied transport cost is **US$38 a barrel for Asia against US$13 for Europe.**[2]

BMI, the Fitch Solutions arm, is blunter: it expects **"a steep sell-off once Washington and Tehran reach a preliminary Hormuz deal"**, forecasting Brent at **US$107** this quarter, **US$112** in the first quarter of 2027 and **US$67** in the last. America's energy secretary, **Chris Wright**, called the spike **"temporary"**. Friday's close of **US$113.43** is still below the **US$118.35** March wartime high.[2]

So one of them is wrong. The oil market is pricing a hostage situation; the bond market is pricing a toll booth. The resolution is a date: **3 November**, when Americans vote, and **4 November**, the first day Gulf officials say they were told to expect strikes.[3]

PARIS — THE CREWS' UNION

Emmanuel Chalard, secretary-general of the CGT merchant-marine officers' union: « *Cela devient extrêmement compliqué de trouver des volontaires pour aller là-bas* » — it is becoming extremely complicated to find volunteers to go there — and what frightens them is « *la banalisation de cette situation de guerre* », the normalisation of a war. **Dated 16 October, outside this window; printed with its date rather than passed off as fresh.**[4]

THE CHATTER · WHO IS PRICING GOLD'S 3.6 PER CENT FALL

Jakob Larsen of BIMCO told CNBC on 30 October that ships are attacked "*really on a daily basis*" and that the convoy system depends on **American naval air cover**. CNBC's observation is the one gold seems to share: a change of control in Congress on **3 November** could pressure the administration to end the war — and with it that cover. The political risk runs both ways. **Ole Hansen** of Saxo Bank named the post-midterm strike reports as the live risk; **paraphrase, no quote obtainable.**[5]

THE SCEPTIC · AGAINST TRUSTING THE BREAKEVEN'S FOUR BASIS POINTS

The case against this page: four basis points on a ten-year breakeven is noise, not a verdict. Breakevens move on liquidity, index-linked supply and convexity as much as on expectations, and 0.04 points would not be reported in a quiet week. Gold has a simpler reading too — after a run to records, a 3.6 per cent day is position-clearing, not prophecy. Goldman Sachs is reported to put the Iran premium at **US$14–18** a barrel, each further month of restriction adding about **US$10** to year-end prices. **Second-hand through a summary, not read in the bank's own words. Dated falsifier:** a ten-year breakeven above 2.45 per cent a fortnight after any strike, and the bond market was making no judgement at all.[6]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Israel has no sworn government until 10 November, and the opposition leader **Gadi Eisenkot** says he will back operations only against "*direct and immediate threats... that cannot wait*" until one exists — the sleeper constraint on any joint strike.[3]

SOURCES 1 US Treasury daily par and real yield curves for 28 and 30 October 2026, read at source; the breakeven is this desk's subtraction. Gold's fall and thirteen-month low from Trading Economics, 30 October. 2 BeInCrypto's reading of JPMorgan and BMI research via Yahoo Finance, 28 October — **neither bank's own note was obtainable.** 3 Times of Israel live coverage, 31 October and 1 November. 4 franceinfo, 16 October 2026. 5 CNBC, 30 October 2026. 6 An Investing.com summary of Goldman Sachs commentary — **second-hand and single-sourced.**

SINGAPORE · THE HAZE ASSESSORS

Wilmar reports US$22.5m of sales to six companies served haze notices

Five of the ten firms had agreed to pay for their own investigators by 31 October, two more are willing, and three have not been named as agreeing at all.

Wilmar International told the Singapore market on **31 October** that it sold fertiliser and diesel for heavy equipment to **six of the ten** companies the National Environment Agency has served over the Indonesian fires, generating about **US$22.5 million** of revenue in the 2025 financial year. It says none of the ten is a subsidiary, that it has no operational or supply-chain tie to the six buyers, and none at all to the other four.[1]

It is the first number anyone has put on the commercial distance between the largest firm on the list and the ones being investigated. It matters because the apparatus Singapore has built rests on relationships: the law reaches companies registered here for smoke that crosses the border, and what it must prove is a link. A fertiliser invoice is a link — and an argument that it is the only one.[1]

The tally as of **31 October**, and it is the cleanest new fact of the week: **five** have agreed to appoint and pay for assessors — Asia Pulp & Paper, its China arm, **Golden Agri-Resources**, **Indofood Agri Resources** and Wilmar. **Two** are willing but unconfirmed: **Kencana Agri**, which the agency will meet, and **First Resources**, from which it says it *"look[s] forward to receiving written confirmation"*. **Three are not mentioned as agreeing** — Bumitama Agri and the two TSH entities.[2]

The panel was named on **30 October**: **Control Risks**, **FTI Consulting** and **Kroll** to investigate; **Dentons Rodyk**, **TSMP**, **WongPartnership** and **Toby Landau KC** on the law. Each company engages one investigator and one legal adviser **selected by the agency**, **at its own expense**, and reports to the agency. What is missing is the power to compel any of it: **Grace Fu** moves amendments to the Act on **3 November**, reported to make non-cooperation an offence — and **the Bill's text was not public on 1 November**. Until it passes, this runs on consent.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE MARKET DID TO WILMAR'S PEERS

Wilmar's peers moved on **20 October**, when Senior Minister **K. Shanmugam** first tied the haze to financing — *"Cannot play hide and seek"*. **Bumitama Agri fell 6.5 per cent intraday**, First Resources to **−4.83**, Golden Agri and Wilmar about **2 per cent** each. Since the panel was named this desk can find **no sell-side note at all**. Campaigners have been louder than analysts: an open letter to the Prime Minister on 15 October, and PM.Haze and SG Climate Rally pressing to lift the **S$2 million** cap. **Reddit and HardwareZone both refused this desk.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · TWELVE YEARS OF THE HAZE ACT, ZERO PENALTIES

Mongabay's **Gabrielle See**, 27 October, assembled the case against Wilmar's audit being worth anything. The Act has been invoked **twice**, in 2015 and 2026, and produced **no prosecution and no fine**; the 2015 cases **remain open**. **Helena Varkkey** of Universiti Malaya: "*influence without enforcement, rather than straightforward failure.*" **Alan Khee-Jin Tan** of NUS argues direct evidence realistically requires **Indonesia** to investigate and share it. **Holly Yang**: "*By the time a report is published, the owner it names may no longer be the owner*" — one chain ends in the British Virgin Islands. **Dated falsifier:** if the 3 November Bill lands *without* a non-cooperation offence, consent is all this ever was.[5]

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COMPANIES CONFIRMED ON 31 OCTOBER AS HAVING AGREED TO APPOINT AND PAY FOR ASSESSORS CHOSEN BY THE REGULATOR; TWO MORE WILLING, THREE UNNAMED[2]

ALSO ON THE DESK

Toa Payoh West. Chee Hong Tat unveiled a master plan on **31 October** for **more than 6,000 homes** over a decade and the town's **first shopping mall**, beside Caldecott station. First project **Toa Payoh Hillside**, about **1,600 flats** with **260 Community Care Apartments**, launches this month — and their eligibility age **drops from 65 to 55**. The exhibition at HDB Hub closes today.[6]

SOURCES 1 Wilmar's revised reply to SGX RegCo, 31 October 2026, as carried by The Straits Times. **Single-sourced and second-hand: sgx.com and Wilmar's own announcement paths returned 404.** 2 National Environment Agency statement of 31 October via MustShareNews — **the agency's own listing rendered empty under every filter.** 3 Ministry of Law and NEA joint release, 30 October, **read in full at source**; Singapore Law Watch, 29 October. 4 CNBC, 20 October 2026. 5 Mongabay, Gabrielle See, 27 October 2026, read at source. 6 AsiaOne, 31 October; **HDB's own listings returned 404.** 7 Joint ministerial release, 29 October, read in full.

BUY IT ONCE · OVER-EAR HEADPHONES

Meze's flagship driver is built by Rinaro, and the spec sheet says so

Spirit Torino publishes no price at all for a US$13,600 headphone; Rosson publishes neither price nor lead time; a Sennheiser HD 600 is made in Ireland.

A full-size headphone is one of the few expensive objects whose quality you can reason about from first principles, because almost all of it is one part. The driver — the thing that turns electricity into sound — is where the money goes, and whether the company whose name is on the cup actually made it is a question with a published answer.[1]

What you pay for, in order. Diaphragm: Sennheiser's HD 800 S uses a **56mm ring radiator** — an annulus rather than a dome, to kill the centre breakup mode — at distortion under **0.02 per cent**. Focal uses an **M-profile beryllium dome**. Then the parts that fail — headband, pads, cable — where the test is whether the maker sells replacements.[2]

Now the ownership truths, each from a company's own page. **Meze**, of Baia Mare, lists the Poet's driver as the "*Rinaro Isodynamic Hybrid Array MZ6*": a Romanian design house around a Ukrainian-Polish driver. **Austrian Audio** was founded in 2017 by **22 former AKG employees** after Vienna closed. **ZMF** machines near St Louis and assembles in Berwyn, Illinois. **Sennheiser's** HD 600, 650 and 800 S are built in **Ireland**.[3]

A Romanian design house around a Ukrainian driver; a German brand built in Ireland. The badge is the last thing to read.

THE CHATTER · WHAT OWNERS SAY OVER-EARS COST IN SINGAPORE

Zeppelin & Co is the one Singapore retailer whose stock this desk could read: **ZMF Vérité Closed S$3,699**, **Bokeh Closed S$1,599**, **Sennheiser HD 800 S S$1,999**, **HD 600 S$389**, **HiFiMAN Edition XS S$329**. Against US list — HD 800 S at US$1,499.95 — plus **9 per cent** GST and ZMF's flat **US$27–52** freight, the local price is competitive and removes a six-week wait. **Six other dealers could not be read at all.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · A US$4,000 DRIVER MEASURED AT US$400

Amir Majidzadeh, who founded Audio Science Review, measured Focal's **US$4,000** Utopia and published this: "*What is missing is not significant enough to leave you disappointed if you paid $400.*" Its top tier is reached **only with free software correction**. On accessories: "*Don't waste your money on such 'high-end' cables.*" The Harman research is candid too: its curve suits **64 per cent** of listeners, and its first results came from **ten trained listeners, most of them Harman employees**.[5]

US$13,600

SPIRIT TORINO'S VALKYRIA TITANIUM, HAND-ASSEMBLED IN TURIN — A FIGURE READ AT A DEALER, BECAUSE THE MAKER'S OWN SITE PUBLISHES NO PRICES AT ALL[6]

NEXT ON THE BENCH

Axes & hatchets — forged heads from named smiths against drop-stamped, and the haft grain that decides which breaks.

Cast-iron kettles & tetsubin — sand-cast against machine-moulded, and the workshops left in Iwate.

Espresso machines (the boiler, not the badge) — heat exchanger against dual boiler, and who welds the vessel.

The climate rule, from Singapore owners rather than a brochure: hold the room at **45 to 55 per cent** humidity, never cycle a set between aircon and no aircon, and choose velour over full-grain leather if it lives outside.[7]

SOURCES 1 Maker pages read at source: Sennheiser HD 600 and HD 800 S, Focal Utopia 2022, ZMF Vérité and Bokeh, Austrian Audio The Composer. 2 The same pages; every description and price is the maker's own. 3 mezeaudio.com, shop.zmfheadphones.com and Sennheiser's manufacture statements; Austrian Audio's founding **from an encyclopaedia entry**. **Not printed for want of sourcing: that Foster Electric makes Denon's drivers, and that Edifier owns STAX.** 4 zeppelinandco.com, 1 November 2026; IRAS and Singapore Customs on the 9 per cent rate. 5 audiosciencereview.com's Utopia and cable reviews; Acoustics Today, Spring 2022; Harman's own write-up. 6 Dealer storefronts, 1 November. 7 mimic-audio.com (**spirittorino.com publishes no prices**); rossonaudiodesign.com; modhouseaudio.com. 8 A StereoNET Singapore thread, read at source; it dates from 2009.

SILICON & SOVEREIGNTY · META AND MICROSOFT

Meta and Microsoft raised US$62.5bn in one day, naming no use

Both prospectuses say "general corporate purposes"; neither names a data centre. Microsoft's filing of 29 October left all ten coupons and maturities blank.

On **Thursday 29 October** two American companies went to the capital markets and came back with **US$62.5 billion**. Meta Platforms sold shares and a convertible preferred worth about **US$37.5 billion**; Microsoft priced a **US$25 billion** bond, its first in the United States since 2017. In the documents that create both obligations, the stated purpose is **"general corporate purposes"**.[1]

Everyone knows what it is for: the buildings and machines that run artificial intelligence, and both firms say so in press releases. But a prospectus is the document an investor can sue on, and in neither does "data centre" appear as a use of proceeds. Meta's own account of its funding reads *"a balanced mix of operating cash flow, investment-grade debt, strategic partnerships, and equity capital."* The thing being built is not in the sentence.[1]

The detail. Meta sold **40,000,000** Class A shares at **US$625.00** through a forward sale, plus **250,000,000** depositary shares on a **6.50 per cent** mandatory convertible — **US$12.46bn** net. Behind that sits an **"approximately US$60 billion"** at-the-market programme, disclosed only in a 26 October free writing prospectus and to be funded by a **Class C** share class the restated charter *"first creates"*. Total: about **US$97.5bn**.[2]

Microsoft's was ten tranches, from a 2028 note at **4.850 per cent** out to **2066** at **6.350** — a forty-year bond funding a compute cycle that turns over in three to five. And the prospectus it filed on 29 October printed each of the ten amounts as "$ aggregate principal amount" and each coupon as "% per annum", under the legend **"SUBJECT TO COMPLETION"**. The numbers arrived next day.[3]

A pattern, then. Anthropic's registration statement of 26 October left its compute commitment blank five times while naming **US$637 billion**; the regulator's database on 1 November shows **no amendment filed**.[4] Amazon, the same Thursday, showed what the money buys: **US$77.3bn** of property and equipment in thirteen weeks.[5]

THE CHATTER · NOBODY DISCUSSED META'S US$62.5BN

A search of Hacker News across the window returns **zero stories** on either the Meta offering or the Microsoft bond. The same forum gave Mistral's release **1,716 points and 439 comments** (p8). The commons that will spend this money did not notice it being raised. In the trade press the signal was demand: Microsoft's book reportedly drew **US$115bn** of orders against US$25bn. **Order books are never filed anywhere; that figure is trade reporting only.**[7]

THE SCEPTIC · AGAINST READING META'S RAISE AS DEMAND

The obvious frame is that Meta and Microsoft borrowed record sums because demand is insatiable. The same week says otherwise: **Microsoft cut** its capital-spending forecast to **US$170bn from US$175bn**, and Alphabet held guidance below estimates. If demand were binding, guidance would rise. It fell. S&P moved Meta's outlook **to negative** on 30 October, forecasting **over US$225bn** of spending in 2027 — while calling the raise "credit positive". **In fairness:** the phrase is boilerplate. **Dated falsifier:** if Meta's spending lands near US$225bn, the money was for what everyone assumed.[6]

US$77.3bn

AMAZON'S PURCHASES OF PROPERTY AND EQUIPMENT IN THE SEPTEMBER QUARTER ALONE, AGAINST A TWELVE-MONTH FREE CASH OUTFLOW OF US$42.4BN[5]

ALSO ON THE DESK

No American export-control rule was made this week. A Federal Register sweep of the Bureau of Industry and Security for 27 October to 3 November returns one document, an unrelated denial order.[8]

What settles it is an amendment. Microsoft's numbers appeared within a day; Anthropic's compute figure has not appeared in six.

SOURCES 1 Meta's two prospectus supplements of 28 October 2026 and Microsoft's pricing term sheet of 30 October, all read at source on the Securities and Exchange Commission's system; the "balanced mix" sentence is from Meta's free writing prospectus of 26 October. 2 Meta's Form 8-K, Certificate of Designations and Form 8-A12B, 29 October. 3 Microsoft's Form 424B2, 29 October — all ten amounts, coupons and maturity years blank. 4 Anthropic's EDGAR filing history, 1 November: seven filings, no amendment. 5 Amazon's third-quarter results, 29 October. 6 S&P Global Ratings, 30 October, **paywalled, not read at source**; CNBC, 29 October, for the guidance. 7 Hacker News via Algolia, 1 November. **Reddit refused this desk for the eighteenth issue running.** 8 Federal Register sweep, 27 October to 3 November. 9 Apple's EDGAR filing history, 1 November.

THE HOME LAB · MISTRAL LARGE 4

Inferencer Labs clocks Mistral Large 4 at 14.5 tokens a second

Mistral published no file size and no memory requirement for its own model; two unrelated toolchains have now converged on about 425 gigabytes for a three-bit build.

The Paris company Mistral gave away the inner workings of its largest artificial-intelligence model on **29 October** and did not say how much memory it needs. For anyone running one at home that is the first thing you need: whether it fits. Its own page states no file size, no total download size and no memory requirement — and advises, remarkably, that if running it yourself is "*subpar*", you should use the company's paid service instead.[1]

On **1 November** somebody filled in the blank. A small outfit called Inferencer Labs published a compressed version and, with it, the first measured speed anyone has put in public: about **14.5 tokens a second** on an Apple M3 Ultra, in a working set of roughly **427 gigabytes**. The firm wrote the compression and the measuring software, so this is a maker measuring its own work — worth knowing before you quote it.[2]

The cross-check is what makes it printable. Unsloth's independently built ladder of the same model publishes sizes from **233GB** at the smallest one-bit build through **302**, **378** and **424GB** to **605GB** at four-bit, **1.12TB** at eight and **2.1TB** uncompressed, with the guidance that the smallest runs on a **256GB** machine. Two unrelated toolchains landing on **424 and 427GB** for a three-bit build of a trillion-parameter model is a fact; neither came from Mistral.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT MISTRAL LARGE 4'S WEIGHTS COST TO RUN

The thread was the week's biggest on Hacker News — **1,716 points, 439 comments** — and the running figures came from the people trying it. **prophesi** notes Unsloth shipped day-zero compressions but that even the lowest still wants about **256GB**. **segmondy** puts the four-bit weights at **about 610GB**, matching Unsloth's 605, and reports three-bit as acceptable. **randunel** describes the rig: "*a $25k custom build with 8 video cards*", and adds that the price only applied to early 2026, because memory has risen sharply since. **dlcarrier**, drily, says he would need about a terabyte more. **Reddit refused this desk, so r/LocalLLaMA does not appear.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE QUALITY TABLE IS NOT MISTRAL LARGE 4'S

The one published speed figure for this model comes attached to a quality table that is **not measured on this model**. Inferencer Labs' own page says its perplexity, token-accuracy and divergence figures "*are from the conversion of GLM 5.1*", citing "*system memory and time constraints*" — and the table contains no row for the build being sold. So the speed is for Mistral Large 4 and the quality is for something else, on the maker's own admission. On the compression itself, **dunefox** reports heavily squeezed models "*nearly unusable*" and smaller uncompressed ones better; **monster_truck** advises testing rather than trusting other people's reports. **Dated falsifier:** an independent measurement of this build at a published hardware configuration, which does not yet exist anywhere.[2]

425GB

WHERE TWO UNRELATED TOOLCHAINS INDEPENDENTLY PUT A THREE-BIT BUILD OF MISTRAL LARGE 4 — A FIGURE MISTRAL ITSELF PUBLISHES NOWHERE[3]

ALSO IN THE LAB

A 763-billion-parameter model on a 12GB card. IST Austria's compression group published builds of DeepSeek V4.1 Flash at **231.32GB**, **248.84** and **265.83**, of which **110.60GB** is two lookup tables read one row at a time — so they can stay on disk. Hence the claim that all three run on a single **12GB** graphics card with the rest in system memory. Accuracy recovery at the recommended build is **100.0 per cent** of the uncompressed original on all three benchmarks. **The card publishes no tokens-a-second figure at all.** **2,294,642** downloads last month.[5]

Nine builds in twenty-seven hours. llama.cpp tagged b12021 to b12024 on 31 October and b12027 to b12032 on 1 November. vLLM, by contrast, has shipped nothing since **v0.32.0 on 18 October** — and its NaN-logits bug, issue **55766**, is still open with no assignee and no linked fix, while the one-line candidate repair, pull request **47123**, has been unmerged for **124 days**.[6]

And a number to hold against a marketing claim: Apple says its new top laptop chip runs models with "*hundreds of billions of parameters*" on the machine. The machine tops out at **128GB**. The smallest build above is 233 (p9).[7]

SOURCES 1 Mistral's own announcement and its model card, read at source 1 November 2026; the card states no size or memory figure anywhere, and the "subpar" advice is its own wording. 2 The inferencerlabs card, read at source, last modified 1 November, for the measurement, the 427-gibibyte working set and the admission that its quality table is from a different model — **a vendor measuring its own work.** 3 The unsloth repository for the same model, read at source. 4 Hacker News item 50289418 via Algolia, 1 November; handles as published. **Reddit refused this desk.** 5 The ISTA-DASLab card, read at source. 6 The llama.cpp releases page and two vLLM items, read as rendered pages. 7 Apple Newsroom, 28 October.

THE KIT · APPLE MACBOOK PRO

Apple opens Singapore orders for a S$6,499 MacBook Pro, resolution unpublished

The first OLED Mac is quoted at 2,000 nits and ten million to one contrast; Apple states no pixel count, no battery capacity and no touch latency.

Apple took Singapore pre-orders from **30 October** for a new professional laptop with a self-illuminating screen and, for the first time in a Mac, a screen you can touch. It arrives on **Friday 6 November**, from **S$3,999** for the smaller model to **S$6,499** for the larger one with the faster chip. Education pricing runs **S$3,789** to **S$6,089**.[1]

What Apple publishes is a brightness and a contrast ratio: up to **2,000 nits** peak for both high- and standard-range content, **ten million to one** contrast, a refresh rate sliding between **10 and 120 hertz**, and a colour space covering **over 80 per cent** of the widest broadcast standard. Weight comes down to **1.36kg** and **1.81kg**; battery life is quoted at "*up to 24 hours*"; the chips are the existing generation, not a new one.[1]

What Apple does not publish is the list that matters. **No pixel resolution and no pixel density** — for a company that has given a resolution for every high-resolution Mac for a decade, on the screen it calls its best. **No battery capacity in watt-hours**, on its first laptop with this panel type, where power draw is the open question. **No touch sampling rate and no touch latency**, although reduced latency is the stated reason the touch layer was built into the panel rather than laid on top. And no panel supplier.[1]

THE CHATTER · HOW TO SWITCH OFF THE MACBOOK PRO'S TOUCHSCREEN

Apple's own page drew **621 points and 1,091 comments** on Hacker News, the biggest hardware thread of the week — and the single most-circulated follow-up, submitted twice in thirteen hours, was a report headlined that you can turn the touchscreen off. **Jason Snell** of Six Colors, writing from the launch, put it plainly: this is "*a conventional laptop with touch, not a convertible*", and macOS adapts "*a little, but not a lot*". His one enthusiastic use is developers touching phone apps in a simulator. **Thread-level signal only: this desk did not read the comment bodies, and Reddit refused it.**[2]

THE SCEPTIC · APPLE'S OWN REVIEWER SAYS 22 HOURS, NOT 24

Snell reports battery life **unchanged** at **22 hours**, and 24 for the larger model — which he calls "*bad news for anyone who was hoping for Apple to maybe stretch battery life*". Apple's release says only "*up to 24*", publishes no figure per size, and no watt-hour capacity against which to check either claim. **This desk could not resolve it and prints both.** The wider case: Apple argued for sixteen years that touchscreen laptops were not a useful application of multi-touch, has now shipped one at about a **US$600** premium over the outgoing model it is *still selling*, on the same chips and roughly the same battery — and the first thing the Mac commentariat wanted was the off switch. **Dated falsifier:** a teardown or a published watt-hour figure showing capacity up materially, and this is a genuine generational step rather than a panel-and-weight upgrade.[2]

S$6,499

THE 16-INCH MACBOOK PRO WITH THE FASTER CHIP, GST INCLUDED — FOR A DISPLAY WHOSE PIXEL COUNT APPLE DOES NOT STATE[1]

ALSO ON THE SHELF

XREAL Aura. The first glasses built on Google's wearable platform opened orders on 28 October at **US$1,099** against a **US$1,279** list nobody has paid, and **every variant on XREAL's own store now reads sold out**. Published: **1920×1200** per eye, **70 degrees** of view, **95g** of glasses on a **265g** tethered puck with a **4,455mAh** cell. **Not published: how many hours that cell lasts.** No reviewer has measured the field of view, the brightness or the runtime. Shipping mid-November to the United States, Canada, Japan and South Korea — **there is no Singapore price and no Singapore availability.**[3]

And the detail a smart-home reader should note: Apple's new iPad mini, **US$699** and out the same Friday, carries the company's own radio chip with **Thread** on it. Apple is quietly putting a border router in a tablet.[4]

SOURCES 1 Apple Newsroom, 28 October 2026, and its Singapore edition carrying the prices and the 30 October pre-order date, both read in full at source. **Every absence listed is an absence from those pages, read line by line.** 2 Six Colors, Jason Snell, 28 October; Hacker News counts via Algolia. **Comment bodies were not read; Reddit refused this desk.** 3 xreal.com/aura and the XREAL US store, read at source 1 November; Road to VR, 28 October. 4 Gear Patrol's round-up, 30 October — **Amazon's own pages 404'd, so this is single-sourced.** 5 Apple Newsroom, 26 October.

OBJECTS & ESCAPES · GLASHÜTTE ORIGINAL

Glashütte Original launched the Senator Aventurine without publishing a price

Four outlets working from one embargo printed EUR 36,900, EUR 37,800, US$40,400 and A$55,200 — and the maker's own page says only "price available upon request".

On **Thursday 29 October** the Saxon watchmaker Glashütte Original launched the **Senator Aventurine** in two versions: a platinum one with a deep blue dial, and a red-gold one with a green dial. The dials are aventurine glass, shot through with the copper flecks that make it look like a night sky, and each is unique. There are no numerals, no date and no seconds hand — hours and minutes only.[1]

What there also is not, is a price. The maker's own page for the platinum reference says **"Price available upon request"**, offers a button to make an appointment, and adds that the figure "*may vary depending on strap fastening*". There is no currency selector anywhere on the site, and none of the nineteen watches in the collection carries a price. Then four publications, working from the same embargo, printed four different numbers.[1]

Here they are. Deployant, citing the press release and including nineteen per cent value-added tax: **EUR 36,900** platinum, **EUR 34,900** gold. Time and Watches, publishing about an hour later: **EUR 37,800** and **EUR 35,800**. Gear Patrol: **US$40,400** and **US$38,200**. Time+Tide and Man of Many: **A$55,200** and **A$52,200**. Two of them are **EUR 900 and EUR 2,000 apart on the same two watches**, within an hour of each other. An American authorised retailer is live at US$40,400. **No Singapore price exists** — the maker's own retailer search for Singapore returns its 404 page.[2]

The watch itself is properly made. In-house **calibre 36-16**, a **100-hour** reserve from a single barrel at **four hertz**, silicon balance spring, hand-engraved balance cock, a **21-carat gold** rotor weight, swan-neck adjustment; **40.00mm** by **10.20mm**. The maker tags both references "*Atelierauftrag*" and states an **"atelier edition without limitation"**: made to order, no cap, each assembled by one watchmaker.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT READERS SAID ABOUT THE SENATOR AVENTURINE

The one live comment thread on it, moderated and dated, is at Monochrome. **Peter S**, 29 October: "*This is gorgeous, but I really wish GO would at least offer a medium sized version of their dress watches*". **Paul Steele**, 30 October, on the indexless dial: "*Is this the watch that people who cannot read time buy?*" A commenter signing as **E** replies: "*if you're buying watches to tell the time, you're in the wrong place.*" **WatchUSeek has no thread on this watch at all, and Reddit refused this desk.**[3]

THE SCEPTIC · PRICE-ON-REQUEST IS A MARGIN INSTRUMENT

Glashütte Original's page concedes the price moves with the buckle; the trade then published four contradictory figures off one embargo. A buyer cannot compare platinum against red gold without an appointment — which is the point. Nor did the coverage push: Gear Patrol calls the pair possibly its reviewer's "*favorite ever*" with **no critical commentary and no question about pricing at all**, and **nobody has measured the 100-hour reserve**. **Tom Austin** of Time+Tide is usefully honest: "*the thin bezel and large dial aperture will make the Senator feel like a larger watch than it really is*". **Dated falsifier:** a published price in any currency on the maker's own site. **The sixth consecutive issue in which a Saxon manufacture has withheld one.**[4]

EUR 2,000

THE GAP BETWEEN TWO OUTLETS' PRICES FOR THE SAME PLATINUM SENATOR AVENTURINE, PUBLISHED WITHIN AN HOUR OF EACH OTHER FROM THE SAME EMBARGO[2]

ALSO ON THE DESK

The one maker that publishes a Singapore price. Bell & Ross announced the BR-05 Chrono Snow Rocket on 28 October, **250 pieces**, in tribute to the speed skier Simon Billy's **255.50 km/h** record. Its Singapore storefront lists **$10,400** on the steel bracelet and **$9,600** on rubber — **though the page shows only a dollar sign, with no currency code.** A Sellita-based automatic chronograph, **60-hour** reserve, 42mm, 100 metres. US figures conflict across two outlets, so none is printed.[5]

SOURCES 1 Glashütte Original's product page for reference 1-36-16-40-03-01 and its collection index, read at source 1 November 2026; every quoted phrase and specification is the maker's own, as is the absence of a price. **No jewel count is printed: one outlet says 27, a retailer 41, the maker none.** 2 Deployant, Time and Watches, Gear Patrol, Time+Tide and Man of Many, 29 October to 1 November, each read at source. The Singapore absence was tested at the maker's own retailer search, which returns a 404. 3 The Monochrome comment thread, read at source, names and dates as published. 4 Time+Tide and Gear Patrol, 29 October, read in full. **Hodinkee refused this desk.** 5 Monochrome, 28 October, and bellross.com's Singapore storefront. 6 schiit.com, read at source.

CULTURE DESK · BOX OFFICE

A24's Elizabeth Holmes film took first place by US$200,684

"You Can See Everything" made US$10,600,685 across 3,243 cinemas in the third-lowest weekend of 2026 — and the figures are Sunday estimates, with finals due Monday.

A documentary about Elizabeth Holmes reached the top of the American box office this weekend, for the first time, by a margin of **US$200,684**. *You Can See Everything*, directed by Nathan Fielder and Lance Oppenheim for A24, took **US$10,600,685** across **3,243** cinemas in its third weekend. *Clayface*, the comic-book film that led on Friday, took **US$10,400,000** across **3,478** and lost over the three days.[1]

Two cautions before anyone calls it a phenomenon. These are Sunday studio estimates, with final numbers due Monday — a gap of two hundred thousand dollars can change hands overnight. And the weekend it won was the **third-lowest of 2026**: about **US$56.0 million** across all 33 reporting films on one tracker's count, in a year running **more than 17 per cent ahead** of the last. The documentary's own gross **fell 43.4 per cent**.[1]

The rest of the chart: *Wildwood*, Laika's stop-motion film, third on **US$7,491,417**; *Wicker* fourth on **US$4,125,000**; a BTS concert film new at sixth on **US$2,800,000** from **1,010** screens. The scores, with their counts, read on 1 November: *Wildwood* at **99 per cent from 158** critics and **88 from 37** on Metacritic; *You Can See Everything* at **96 per cent from 203**; *Clayface* at **77 per cent from 206** against a Metacritic **59 from 45**.[2]

And the film that opened on Halloween to nothing. *Christmas at the Kringles*, released by Briarcliff on **30 October**, stands at **0 per cent from 26 critic reviews** and **21 from 5** on Metacritic, with too few verified audience ratings to generate a score at all. The zero has held at every count — **19, then 24, then 26** reviews across four days. It does not appear in the top ten or in the 33-film chart; one trade report put Friday at **US$370,000** and **"around a million dollars for the weekend, or less"**.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHAT AUDIENCES SAID ABOUT YOU CAN SEE EVERYTHING

The exit polling on the Holmes documentary is unusual for the form: **A−** from CinemaScore, **4.5 stars** on PostTrak, **90 per cent** saying they would definitely recommend it and **80 per cent** that it was better than expected — one report instead gives 98 and 91. Its second weekend **rose 25 per cent** to US$19.5m from a US$15.6m opening as it went from 855 to 2,655 cinemas; at **US$63.9 million** it is now among the highest-grossing documentaries ever released. **These figures are search-aggregated from trade coverage this desk did not open, and Reddit refused it, so there is no forum read on this page.**[4]

THE SCEPTIC · YOU CAN SEE EVERYTHING'S PER-SCREEN AVERAGE IS CONTESTED

The metric a documentary's phenomenon framing rests on is per-screen average, and it is not agreed. On the two box-office trackers' **3,243** cinemas it is **US$3,268**; on the Associated Press's **2,655** — which appears to be last weekend's count carried forward — it is **US$3,992**. A **22 per cent** swing in the headline number. The weekend market total is likewise unsettled: **US$56.0m** on one tracker against the news agency's *"below US$63 million"*, about seven million apart. And the more newsworthy figure may be the loser's: *Clayface* is reported at a **US$44 million** production budget against **US$44.1 million** of domestic takings — after two weekends a comic-book film has merely matched its cost at home. **Dated falsifier:** Monday's finals.[1]

0% from 26

CHRISTMAS AT THE KRINGLES ON ROTTEN TOMATOES — THE ZERO HELD AS THE COUNT ROSE FROM 19 TO 24 TO 26 REVIEWS IN FOUR DAYS[3]

ALSO ON THE DESK

A twenty-year-old album is number one. My Chemical Romance's *The Black Parade* went from **162 to 1** on the British album chart for the week to 5 November, in its **74th** chart week. Amy Winehouse's *Back to Black* rose **112 to 4** in its **571st**. Jamie Miller's "Babydoll" holds the singles top spot for a second week, with **no new entries in the top ten**.[5]

SOURCES 1 Box Office Mojo's weekend 44 chart and The Numbers' chart of 30 October 2026, both read at source, for every gross, cinema count and change, and the 33-film total; the Associated Press via CP24, 1 November, for the year-to-date figure, the budget reports and its differing counts. **All weekend figures are Sunday estimates.** 2 Rotten Tomatoes and Metacritic pages for each title, read 1 November with their review counts. 3 The two pages for *Christmas at the Kringles*, read 1 November; Showbiz411, 31 October, for the Friday figure — **single-sourced, and no weekend gross appears on either tracker.** 4 Exit polling as reported in trade coverage, **search-aggregated, not read at source.** 5 The Official Charts Company, week of 30 October to 5 November. 6 NME, 29 October, and The AU Review, 31 October. **Both scoring sites returned 403 and Billboard's charts a payment wall.**

RAISING THEM WELL · PEDIATRICS ON SOCIAL MEDIA

No anxiety link in 11,279 twelve-year-olds, Pediatrics reports

Across four annual transitions, problematic social media use predicted depression in two windows at betas of .06 and .07, and anxiety in none — and depression predicted later use just as strongly.

The journal *Pediatrics* published the largest study yet of heavy social media use in young adolescents on **1 November**, and it starts at exactly the age this desk writes for. The cohort's average age at the first measurement was **12.01 years**; there were **11,279** of them, followed annually for five years. The finding most parents will want is the one about anxiety, and it is a negative: across four years of transitions, heavy use **never once** predicted later anxiety.[1]

Depression is a different answer, and a smaller one than the headlines imply. The study separates two things usually confused: whether children who use social media heavily are more depressed than other children, and whether *this* child's use going up predicts *this* child's symptoms going up. It is the second question that matters to a parent, and the authors report the effect in standardised units, where **zero means nothing** and anything under about a tenth is small.[1]

The numbers, with their confidence intervals. Heavy use predicting later depressive symptoms: **.03** in the first transition, with an interval straddling zero; **.06** in the second and **.07** in the third, both excluding zero; **.02** in the fourth, straddling again. Two of four windows, at .06 and .07. Anxiety: **.01, .02, .04, .02**, and **not one interval excludes zero**. And the reverse direction — depression predicting later heavy use — came in at **.06 and .05** in the same middle windows. It runs both ways, equally.[1]

The authors' own limitations deserve print. Symptoms were **parent-reported**, and they note caregivers "*may miss internalizing symptoms that are less visible to them*". Measurement was **annual**, which "*may miss shorter-term processes*". The questionnaire went only to children who **already had an account**. And, in their words, **"cross-lagged effects were small in absolute size"**. Associations were stronger and more consistently two-way **among girls**.[1]

THE CHATTER · THE JOURNAL'S OWN COMMENTARY ON THE PEDIATRICS FINDING

Pediatrics ran a commentary in the same issue, by **Jenny Radesky** of Michigan and **Sarah Domoff** of Albany, under a title that concedes the paper's central point: **"It's a 2-Way Street"**. It leads with the *reverse* direction — that higher depressive symptoms predicted heavier problematic use a year later across ages 13 to 14 and 14 to 15. **This desk could not read its text: the publisher returned 403 on both addresses and it is not in the open archive, so the title, the authors and that one claim are what can be stood behind.**[2]

THE SCEPTIC · WHO IS PAID TO SAY SOCIAL MEDIA HARMS CHILDREN

Print the disclosure. On this paper: **"DA Christakis is currently serving as an expert witness in social media litigation. The remaining authors have no conflict to declare."** Dr Christakis is also editor of a sister journal. The lead author is funded by a National Institutes of Health career award and the Doris Duke Charitable Foundation, which the paper says had no role. Separately, the sceptics' own position is published and attributable: a 2026 peer-reviewed review relays **Candice Odgers** and **Andrew Przybylski** as finding associations "*generally small but consistent, and depend more on patterns and contexts of use than total time spent online*", and that "*overall screen time shows weak and inconsistent associations with depression and anxiety*". The counter-counter, fairly: near-universal exposure means even modest effects matter at population scale. **General guidance, not medical advice.**[3]

0 of 4

ANNUAL TRANSITIONS IN WHICH PROBLEMATIC SOCIAL MEDIA USE PREDICTED LATER ANXIETY SYMPTOMS, ACROSS 11,279 ADOLESCENTS AVERAGING 12.01 YEARS[1]

SOURCES 1 Nagata JM and others, "Problematic Social Media Use and Depressive and Anxiety Symptoms in Adolescents", *Pediatrics*, 1 November 2026, 158(5):e2025075060 — full text read at source, including every beta, interval, limitation and disclosure quoted. Random-intercept cross-lagged models across five annual assessments of the Adolescent Brain Cognitive Development study. **The authors report no p-values for these paths; significance is read off whether the interval excludes zero.** 2 Radesky J, Domoff SE, same issue, e2026077848 — **title and authors verified; the text returned 403, so nothing is quoted from it.** 3 Sharma V, Sharma A, *Cureus*, 6 February 2026, for the Odgers and Przybylski attributions only. 4 Bourke M and others, *JAMA Pediatrics*, May 2026, 180(5):500–509, read at source.

THE TWEEN YEARS · DINNER AND SADNESS

Family dinners tracked lower sadness in 5,298 tweens, a Stanford-led team finds

A Journal of Adolescent Health paper published 30 October names the two behaviours; more texting and video-chat went with more sadness, at p below .01.

The *Journal of Adolescent Health* published a study on **30 October**, by a team at SRI International with Stanford and two other universities, of more than five thousand children averaging **12.5 years** old. It found that two ordinary household behaviours tracked with less sadness, and it names them. Having dinner together, and talking with parents about plans. Household conflict went the other way. So did time spent texting, on social media and on video calls.[1]

What the paper can and cannot tell a parent needs saying before the findings. It reports **directions and probabilities only**: every result below is significant at better than one in a hundred, and the authors publish **no effect sizes and no confidence intervals** in the abstract, with the full text behind a paywall this desk could not pass. So the direction is solid and **the magnitude is unknown**. Nor is there a funding statement or a competing-interests declaration anywhere this desk could reach.[1]

The findings, then. Across two surveys of **5,298** and **5,051** children, household conflict predicted **higher** sadness; positive parent-child engagement and relationships predicted **lower** sadness; and time on texting, social media and video chat predicted **greater** sadness. The groups of children with less digital contact, stronger engagement and better relationships had the lowest sadness scores — and children who shifted **towards less** digital contact between the two surveys showed a stronger fall in sadness.[1]

And now the limitation that governs all of it, which the abstract does not flag. **The surveys were run in May and August 2020.** This is a lockdown cohort, published six years later; those twelve-year-olds are eighteen now. In 2020, a video call was a *substitute* for school and friends. For a Singapore secondary-schooler in 2026 it is an *addition* to them. Whether "video chat makes tweens sadder" survives that change is exactly the question this design cannot answer.[1]

THE CHATTER · SINGAPORE ACTED ON TWEEN SADNESS WITHOUT THE STUDY

Singapore did not wait for a sadness study. On the digital half of this paper's finding it has already legislated, and on the dinner half it has not. From **January 2026**, the Ministry of Education has barred secondary students from using smartphones and smartwatches **during school hours** — and the scope is wider than most parents realise: it covers **recess, co-curricular activities, and supplementary, enrichment and remedial lessons**. Devices go into designated storage or school bags. Primary schools have had comparable guidelines since early 2025; junior colleges and Millennia Institute students are **expected to self-manage**. Each school sets its own discipline rules within the guidelines, under the Grow Well SG programme. The policy was announced on **30 November 2025**.[2]

THE SCEPTIC · AGAINST ACTING ON A 2020 SADNESS SURVEY

The honest objection to this paper is that it measures the wrong era and reports no magnitude. A direction without an effect size cannot be weighed against anything — not against sleep, not against friendship, not against the cost of the argument you will have confiscating a phone. And the behaviours it endorses are the behaviours every parenting study endorses, which is a sign of a robust finding and also of one that was never in doubt. What it does usefully supply is the *order* of the levers: conflict in the house and the quality of the relationship sat alongside digital hours in the same models, and both were significant at the same threshold. **Dated falsifier:** the full text, when the journal opens it, reporting a trivial effect size for the digital-hours term. **General guidance, not medical advice.**[1]

p < .01

THE ONLY STATISTIC THE AUTHORS PUBLISH FOR EVERY FINDING — DIRECTION AND SIGNIFICANCE, WITH NO EFFECT SIZE AND NO INTERVAL ANYWHERE IN THE ABSTRACT[1]

SOURCES 1 Gombert-Labedens M and others, "Adolescents During the Pandemic", *Journal of Adolescent Health*, online ahead of print 30 October 2026 — abstract read at source; 5,298 and 5,051 children from the Adolescent Brain Cognitive Development study, mean ages 12.5 and 12.7, measured with the National Institutes of Health sadness instrument. **The full text is paywalled: no effect size, interval, funding statement or competing-interests declaration was obtainable, and the May–August 2020 fieldwork date is this desk's flag, not the authors'.** 2 Ministry of Education guidance announced 30 November 2025, effective January 2026, under Grow Well SG.

THE MACRO DESK · AMERICAN CONSUMPTION

US consumers spent US$113bn more in September, buying no extra goods

Petrol took US$45.7bn of the increase and motor vehicles gave back US$14bn, while real disposable income fell 0.3 per cent in a quarter that grew at a 3.4 per cent annual rate.

The United States Bureau of Economic Analysis published its September household accounts on **Thursday 29 October**. Americans spent **US$113.1 billion** more that month than in August. Adjusted for price rises, they took home **US$2.6 billion** more in goods and services — which the bureau's own table rounds to **zero**.[1]

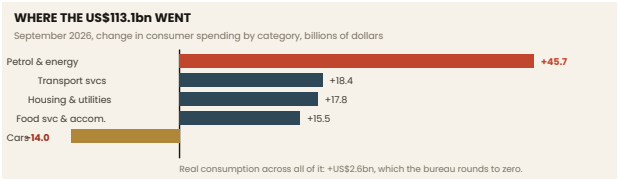
Why that matters to anyone not watching the data calendar: almost everything a global share-and-bond portfolio earns turns on whether households in the largest economy are buying more, or only paying more for the same. The two look identical in a spending total and opposite in a company's results. September was the second kind.[1]

The income side fits. Personal income rose **0.2 per cent** and, after inflation, disposable income **fell 0.3**; saving was **US$911.1 billion**, a rate of **3.8 per cent**. The price gauge rose **3.6 per cent** over the year, **3.1** excluding food and fuel — and the quarterly figure released the same morning put growth at **3.4 per cent** annualised, against 2.2.[2]

A 3.4 per cent economy with a flat consumer. The growth is nominal; the goods are not.

The regime, named plainly: **higher-for-longer, with growth**. The ten-year Treasury yield ended Friday at **4.94 per cent**, the inflation-protected ten-year at **2.60**; the gap — what investors demand to cover a decade of inflation — is **2.34 per cent** on this desk's subtraction, and the two-year at **4.56** leaves the curve **38 basis points** upward-sloping.[3]

One force, four answers. Equities are carried by nominal growth and squeezed by the real yield they are discounted against; the two cancel. Bonds collect a coupon and hedge badly. Gold should have won a **28-basis-point** fall in real yields and did not, at **US$3,876**.[4] Bitcoin was **US$77,860** on Sunday evening, down **7.8 per cent** in thirty days.[5]



A *Meridian* original, drawn from the Bureau of Economic Analysis's own category chart in its September release.[1]

THE VERDICT · WHAT SEPTEMBER'S US$113BN MEANS

All-world equities: revenue growth is real and the discount rate is not falling — margins decide the index, not multiples. **Global bonds:** a good coupon, a poor hedge. **Gold:** its textbook driver moved 28 basis points its way in October and it fell anyway — the monetary bid sets this price. **Bitcoin:** down 7.8 per cent in a month against flat equities — a liquidity proxy, not a haven. **Education, not investment advice.**[6]

THE SCEPTIC · AGAINST READING SEPTEMBER AS WEAKNESS

One flat month inside a **3.4 per cent** quarter is noise, and the composition proves it: a petrol spike lifts nominal spending and depresses the real figure, and **August's** real consumption rose **0.5 per cent** on the same table. The reply is the saving rate — **3.8 per cent** with real income falling cannot run long. **Falsifier: the October accounts, 25 November.**[1]

What to watch: the October accounts on **25 November**, and whether the next payroll print supports a 3.4 per cent economy.

SOURCES 1 Bureau of Economic Analysis, "Personal Income and Outlays, September 2026", release BEA 26–46, 29 October — the document downloaded and text-extracted in full; every figure here, and the category chart, is read from it. 2 BEA, third-quarter advance estimate, 29 October. 3 US Treasury par and real yield curves, read at source; the breakeven and the curve spread are this desk's arithmetic. 4 Spot gold at 21:20 UTC, 1 November; **the London benchmark's file is licence-gated.** 5 CoinGecko, 21:14 UTC, 1 November — a daily series, not a close. 6 This desk's reading of the above. 7 European Central Bank reference rates, 30 October.

THE RABBIT HOLE · RUG TUFTING

Five of ten Singapore tufting studios have closed or paused

The hobby that went viral on video in 2020 is consolidating: a specialist retailer has turned into a general craft shop, and r/Tufting's second-biggest flair is "Newbie Needing Help".

Rug tufting is making a rug with a machine the size and noise of a cordless drill. You stretch a sheet of woven cloth across a frame until it is **drum-tight** — the trade's own word, and the thing beginners get wrong — then draw your design on the *back* of the cloth while the gun punches yarn through it hundreds of times a minute. The pile grows on the front, mirror-imaged.[1]

Why anyone falls for it is speed. Hand-knotting a rug takes months; a gun lays a square foot of pile in minutes, which is why the craft spread through video rather than through craft magazines. There are two pile types and the choice is permanent for the piece: leave the loops whole and you get a nubby surface that holds a thin line faithfully and shows every wobble; let the little scissors inside the gun snip each loop and you get a plush, forgiving surface that blurs fine detail. Beginners are told to start on cut.[1]

Then comes the part nobody puts in the video. With the rug still stretched, you brush adhesive across the whole back so the yarn can never pull out, and wait **12 to 48 hours** for it to cure before the piece comes off the frame. Only then do you shear the fuzz flat and **carve** — cutting valleys between colour blocks so shapes read crisply. Then a second backing cloth, then a bound edge. A retailer that sells the machines and has no reason to say so puts the finishing at "*roughly half the job either way*", and a first rug at **15 to 20 hours** that "*will not look like the one in your head*".[2]

The scale, as far as anybody can count it. The main gathering place, **r/Tufting**, has about **53,000** members, up **7,000** in a year; the adjacent and older punch-needle community has **36,000** and is growing faster in percentage terms. There is **no tufting Discord of any scale**, **no dedicated forum anywhere**, and **no convention** — this desk looked. The industry's own market research is worse than useless: three vendors sell estimates of the tufting-machine market at **US$195.4 million**, **US$2.13 billion** and **US$3.44 billion**. Seventeen times apart. Nobody credibly knows.[3]

THE CHATTER · WHY THE FOUNDER OF TUFT THE WORLD STOPPED TUFTING

Tim Eads, who co-founded the largest Western tufting supplier, told *Technical.ly* in 2024 that long-term hand tufting "*really destroys your body*". He has **carpal tunnel** and now tufts less, having bought a computer-controlled machine instead — **sixteen feet tall, twenty-four wide** — and reports that commenters routinely accuse him of removing the artistry. His own words on that reaction: "*So many people say there needs to be some kind of pain in art creation.*" It is the best quotation available on the hand-against-machine argument, and it comes from the man who sells the guns.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · TUFTING'S OWN SEARCH RESULTS HAD THE NUMBERS REMOVED

Search this hobby in 2026 and you reach affiliate content farms dressed as community — one of the "best tufting guns" pages is hosted on a domain named after a video game. This desk read two pages of one such site and found **no author, no date, no prices and no fabric weights**, each ending in a shopping affiliate link. One of them states, in its own words, that it **removed fixed ounce weights, size thresholds, bounce measurements and re-tension schedules** from its guidance. For a buy-once reader the practical instruction follows: read the sellers' own dated knowledge bases, which are good, and ignore the round-ups entirely.[5]

17×

THE SPREAD BETWEEN THREE VENDORS' PUBLISHED ESTIMATES OF THE SAME TUFTING-MACHINE MARKET, ALL SOLD AS RESEARCH[3]

What the next two pages descend into: the machines and what they cost, from a **US$165** gun to a **US$8,999** desktop robot that is not shipping; the commission economy and why its best-priced artist has closed her queue; the four named hazards; and the five Singapore studios that are still open.

SOURCES 1 Tuft the World's instructional pages of 24 July 2026 and its adhesive page, read at source; Craftphilia's troubleshooting guide, Miles Barrett, 19 August 2026. 2 Craftphilia's difficulty guide — **the two quoted phrases came through a search summary, not the page.** 3 GummySearch's pages for both subreddits, each stating "last updated October 27, 2026" — **single-sourced, because Reddit refused this desk**; Global Market Insights report GMI11702, August 2026, read at source, with the two rival figures from search summaries. 4 Sarah Huffman, *Technical.ly*, 2 August 2024, read at source. 5 tuftingtutorials.com, two pages read at source.

The machine is the whole decision, and the ladder is shorter than it looks. At the bottom, unbranded guns sell for about **£14** and get one line here and no more. The real floor is the pair that built the hobby: the **AK-I**, which cuts, and the **AK-II**, which loops, at **US$165** each from the cheapest reputable seller or **€179** in the European Union. One gun, one job.[1]

Above them sits the machine a buy-once reader should actually start with, and the thing people get wrong about it. **The Duo** does both pile types — you disengage the internal scissors, no part needed — and comes in at **US$199**, **US$225** and **US$260**. Those are *not* three settings on one gun. They are **three separate machines**, for low pile of 8 to 16 millimetres, medium of 20 to 30, and high of 35 to 45. Choosing the wrong one is the commonest expensive mistake in the category. The same supplier's house recommendation, the **AK-V**, is **US$250**, or **US$198** from the discount seller without a warranty.[1]

What changed in 2026 is not capability. It is warranty and weight. Dutch Tufting badges a brushless **AK-V PRO** and **AK-DUO PRO** as "Model 2026" at **€209** and **€179** — digital speed readout, five to forty stitches a second, guide light — and, more to the point, **two years of warranty with free first-year maintenance**. Set that against the **thirty days** Tuft the World gives on its pneumatic flagship, **voided if you adjust the machine yourself**, with a one-year service warranty sold separately at **US$100**. **Buy the warranty, not the gun.**[2]

And weight became a headline specification for the first time. Clawlab's **H1**, **US$185.99**, weighs about **1.2 pounds** against a typical three, in a fully enclosed housing with a sixty-second auto-standby. The trade-offs are real and its own page states them: **cut pile only, a fixed 15mm pile, mains-tethered, and one to twenty stitches a second** — half the speed of the brushless guns. It is a comfort machine, not a capability machine. It is also downstream of a supplier's founder saying in public that hand tufting gave him carpal tunnel (p15).[3]

The high end is pneumatic and needs an air compressor nobody includes. The **AK-III** is **US$599**, adjustable from 20 to 60 millimetres across nine needles — and its product record was created in **September 2018**. Any guide selling it as new is wrong. The **ZQ-III** above it is where this market's honesty collapses: **US$1,149** at one seller and **US$2,100** at another, the same model, both read on the same day. **An 83 per cent spread. There is no price discipline here at all.**[4]

At the top, two worlds. **EFAB** of Krefeld builds the industrial article — gantries of **1,250 to 2,000 kilograms** at **2,000 stitches a minute** — and publishes **no price at all**. And **Craftphilia** claims the first desktop machine, **US$8,999** and **US$9,999**: 17 kilograms, 800 stitches a minute, cut pile only.[5]

THE CHATTER · WHAT OWNERS SAY ABOUT THE H1'S WEIGHT

The strongest first-person accounts available are on the sellers' own pages. On Clawlab's H1 page, **85 reviews**, undated: **Kate** writes "*The gun is a gamechanger. You had me at 'light as a water bottle'*"; **Vance Loveless**, "*probably the best gun to start with*". **Seller-hosted, unverified and undated** — the best this category offers, because Reddit was unreachable and no independent reviewer has tested any gun here.[3]

THE SCEPTIC · CRAFTPHILIA'S US$8,999 MACHINE IS NOT SHIPPING

Every variant of both Craftphilia machines reads **Sold Out**, and the site's own banner says the machines "*launch this October*" beside a crowdfunding waitlist. Two further things this desk verified: the maker's own guide says the cheaper model "*costs $150 less*" than the dearer one while its shop shows a **US$1,000** gap; and two of its consumables are listed at **US$0.00**. There is no independent review, no owner and no third-party coverage anywhere. **Treat "world's first fully automated tufting machine" as an unverified vendor claim and write it up in 2027. Dated falsifier:** a shipped unit in a named owner's hands.[5]

83%

THE PRICE GAP BETWEEN TWO RETAILERS FOR THE IDENTICAL ZQ-III PNEUMATIC MACHINE — US$1,149 AGAINST US$2,100, BOTH READ ON 1 NOVEMBER[4]

THE REST OF THE KIT, AT THE QUALITY ENTRY POINT

Frame from **US$60** bought, or **US$30–50** in lumber and hardware if you build it — and do not buy a 24-by-24-inch one, which becomes dead weight the moment you want a real rug. **Cloth** from **US$28** a yard. **Yarn** at **US$18–28** a cone, three or four cones for a two-foot square. **Adhesive US$50** for about 200 square feet, water-based, latex-free and declared free of volatile compounds — which is what makes this hobby possible in a flat at all.[6]

SOURCES 1 Prices read at each seller's page on 1 November 2026: tuftingunclub.com, ohmytuft.com, tufttheworld.com. The three-machines point is Tuft the World's own listing structure. 2 dutchtufting.com's two "Model 2026" pages and Tuft the World's warranty wording. **No release date is published for either PRO machine, and one retailer listing carries metadata 763 days old.** 3 clawlab.com's H1 page and its ergonomics article of 4 February 2026; every claim is the maker's own and the reviews are seller-hosted and undated. 4 Tuft the World's AK-III listing, product record created 1 September 2018; the two ZQ-III prices read the same day. 5 efab.de; craftphilia.com's shop, guide and banner, including the price contradiction and the zero-priced consumables. 6 Tuft the World's costing article of 2 August 2026.

The commission is what people aim at, and the clearest view of it is one artist's shop. **TuftTay** charges **US$60 to US$100 a square foot** for custom work and sells ready-made pieces at **US$70 to US$200**. Its commission page currently reads: **"Sorry Not taking Submissions."** The best-priced commission artist in the hobby has shut her queue.[1]

The process, where published, is exacting. **Yarnqueer** takes a **50 per cent deposit** to start design, allows **three revisions**, states that "*rugs take up to 8 weeks to complete*", and ships after the balance is paid. Its finished benchmark — 47 by 60 inches at **US$2,000** — is about **US$102 a square foot**. At eight weeks a rug, that is a handful a year.[1]

Then the sums that govern it. The hobby's pricing orthodoxy is **US$30 an hour** and two to three times materials; Tuft the World puts a large rug at "*10+ hours and $80 in materials*" before design and finishing. The same company will sell you a detailed rug off its computer-controlled machine, fully finished, at about **US$35 a square foot**. **A machine undercuts the hand-tufter by two-thirds.** People make money here by teaching it and selling supplies to those who just learned — which is what every surviving business in this piece does.[2]

Singapore is the best countable microcosm anywhere. **WeTuft**, founded in 2022 by **Edmond Wong** and now in about **3,000 square feet** at Gillman Barracks, runs sessions from **S$128** to a ten-hour **S$588**. **About You Studio** in Bugis does the conversion event: **45 minutes, S$55**, and you carry it home that evening. **Tuft Club** starts at **S$70**, minimum age 16; **beadbadwolf** teaches on request at **S$135**.[3]

What there is not, is a shop. **This desk found no Singapore tufting-supply retailer at all.** The nearest chain is Malaysian — **Tuftspace** and **Tuftin' Asia**, at roughly a **50 per cent premium** on buying direct, in exchange for three-day freight and somebody to telephone. The first ninety days, honestly costed: a class at **S$55**, then about **US$375 to US$450** all in — and in a flat the binding constraint is not money but a compressor indoors and somewhere to cure glue for two days.[3]

THE CHATTER · THE FOUR HAZARDS TUFT THE WORLD NAMES ITSELF

The supplier's own safety page of **3 October 2026** lists them: **noise** — "*like a drill or loud sewing machine… gradual hearing loss*" — **inhalable yarn fibres**, **adhesive fumes**, and **repetitive strain**. Its advice: earplugs *every time*, a mask indoors, gloves for adhesive, breaks every **30 to 45 minutes**, and a balancer to hang the machine's weight off your wrist. Clawlab's guide names the injuries — **"Tufter's Wrist"**, tendonitis from a death grip — and notes a frame above shoulder height tires you **within 10 to 15 minutes**. **Both are published by firms selling the solution.** For glue vapour the right protection is an organic-vapour cartridge, not a particle mask.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · THE HOLE IN THIS DESK'S OWN TUFTING RESEARCH

The one thing this desk wanted and could not get is an attributable account of someone quitting — selling the gun after four rugs. That lives on Reddit, which refused this session, and **no quotation will be invented to fill the gap**. What can be said is structural: **"Newbie Needing Help" is the second-largest flair** on a 53,000-member community; **five of ten** Singapore studios are closed or paused; **Tuftinglove** now redirects to a general craft shop whose newest lines are socks and crates; **there is no second-hand market at all. A fifty per cent studio mortality rate in one city is the story the viral-craft coverage never writes.**[5]

US$35/sq ft

WHAT TUFT THE WORLD'S OWN MACHINE CHARGES FOR A FINISHED CUSTOM RUG, AGAINST US$60–102 A SQUARE FOOT FROM THE HAND-TUFTERS IT SELLS GUNS TO[2]

NEXT DESCENTS

Sashiko & boro mending — running-stitch repair as a discipline: indigo cloth, needle gauges, and a live argument about who may teach it.

Astrophotography on a budget — where the processing is the craft, a S$500 tracker beats a S$5,000 telescope, and Singapore's light pollution is the honest obstacle.

Scale model railways — finescale standards, sound decoders and layout operation as simulation, with a locomotive market that has a hard second-hand floor.

The glossary that matters is four words: **drum-tight**, **cut**, **loop** and **carving**. Everything else is in a seller's dated knowledge base.[1]

SOURCES 1 tufttay.com and yarnqueer.com's commissions page, read at source 1 November 2026; the per-square-foot figure is this desk's arithmetic on Yarnqueer's own published piece. 2 Tuft the World's pricing article of 3 October 2026 and its custom pages; priceyourcraft.com for the hourly orthodoxy. 3 Studio prices read at each studio's own site, 1 November; the closed studios from Sassy Mama Singapore, last updated January 2026; tuftspace.com and tuftinasia.com. **The absence of a Singapore supply retailer was tested by search and at every studio's shop pages.** 4 Tuft the World's safety page of 3 October 2026 and Clawlab's guide of 4 February — **both published by firms selling the remedy**; the cartridge point from a search summary. 5 GummySearch's flair data; the Tuftinglove redirect, verified by following it. **Reddit refused this desk.** 6 Tuft the World's costing article and the totals built from the prices on this spread.

THE LONG GAME · THRESHOLD TRAINING

A PeerJ meta-analysis puts threshold gains at 38.7 per cent above, 18.4 below

Thirteen studies and 338 people, published 22 October — and the authors report heterogeneity near 89 per cent, meaning the studies substantially disagree.

The journal *PeerJ* published a meta-analysis on **22 October** finding that the training hours which actually moved endurance were the ones just *above* a comfortable pace, by a factor of roughly two. That cuts against the dominant training religion for anyone in their forties: the easy hour, long and conversational.[1]

What is being measured is a threshold — the effort level at which the body tips from steady to struggling, and the thing endurance training is really trying to push higher. The paper pooled **13 studies, 24 training groups, 338 people**, pre-registered, and sorted every group by whether it trained below, at or above threshold. For the lower of the two thresholds the improvement was **+38.7 per cent** for training above it, **+14.7** at it and **+18.4** below, with intensity significant at **p = 0.017**. For the higher threshold the pattern was graded: **+2.6 per cent** below, about **+7** at, **+12.2** above, at **p = 0.008**.[1]

Of the three things the authors tested as explanations — intensity, how trained the subjects were, and how long the programme ran — **only intensity** was consistently associated with the change. Which is a clean finding, and almost immediately qualified by the authors themselves.[1]

THE CHATTER · WHAT THE THRESHOLD AUTHORS SAY THEY CANNOT SHOW

Their own words, and there are a lot of them. **"Substantial heterogeneity persisted"** — at **about 89 per cent** for the lower threshold and **53** for the higher, which at 89 means the studies effectively disagree with one another. They attribute it to **"threshold identification bias"**, because the trials did not even define the threshold the same way, some using blood lactate and some breath analysis, and to differing background training. They can only speak **"within the limited supra-threshold ranges represented"** — so how far above is too far is unanswered. And their conclusion is hedged in print: individualised work above threshold with regular reassessment **"seems to be recommended"**.[1]

THE SCEPTIC · WHO PUBLISHED THE THRESHOLD PAPER

One of its co-authors, **Carlo Ferri Marini**, is **an academic editor at the journal that published it**. The paper carries no funding statement; the journal is author-pays. And 338 people across 13 studies is a small evidence base on which to overturn a decade of easy-pace advice — the authors say so themselves, calling for **"further well-controlled studies... before definitive training recommendations can be made"**. **In fairness to the finding:** it was pre-registered, it used the more conservative of the available pooling methods, and the graded pattern across three intensity bands is the shape you would expect if the effect were real. **Dated falsifier:** a single well-controlled trial with one threshold definition throughout. **Not medical advice; any change to training should go through a reader's own trainer and doctor.**[1]

$I^2 \approx 89\%$

HETEROGENEITY IN THE AEROBIC-THRESHOLD ANALYSIS — THE MEASURE OF HOW FAR THE POOLED STUDIES DISAGREE WITH EACH OTHER[1]

ALSO ON THE DESK

The weekend warrior gets an answer, and the authors refuse to call it equivalence. A meta-analysis restricted to cohorts averaging **40 or over** puts all-cause mortality for weekend-concentrated exercise against regular activity at a hazard ratio of **1.019**, interval **0.851 to 1.221**, from three reports covering **452,513** people. Certainty of evidence: **very low**. Their caveat, verbatim: this **"does not establish equivalence because direct evidence was limited"** and weekly activity volume **"was not uniformly matched"**.[2]

A wearable company funded a wearable study and then published the kill shot itself. Across **1,649,083 person-days** from **11,733** adults, sleeping beside a dog, cat or child moved resting heart rate by **0.8 to 1.1 beats** and sleep duration by **5.5 to 9.6 minutes** — and the authors write: **"Despite statistical significance, all standardized effect sizes were small"**, in a range of **0.008 to 0.045**. The study was funded by the company; two of three authors are its employees and one holds stock options. The disclosure is exemplary, and the lesson is about how to read the numbers a strap shows you each morning.[3]

SOURCES 1 Peric R and others, "Moderators of metabolic threshold adaptations", *PeerJ*, 22 October 2026, 14:e21806, pre-registered — read at source for every percentage, probability, heterogeneity figure, quoted limitation and the editorial affiliation. 2 Lu J and others, *Journal of Science and Medicine in Sport*, online ahead of print 6 October 2026. 3 Montoye AHK and others, *Nature and Science of Sleep*, 24 October 2026, read at source including the full funding and interests statement. 4 Qin S and others, *Sleep Health*, online ahead of print 9 October 2026; the joint-lab affiliation is the only disclosure in the record. **Reddit refused this desk.**

THE DIARY · TWO DATES TO PUT IN PRINT

Tokyo's Kabukiza opens December sales on 14 November, the basho on 5 December

Japan's marquee events are closing six to twelve weeks earlier than the guides assume: the Fukuoka sumo tournament is sold out on every one of its fifteen days, with no door sales.

SINGAPORE

BOOK NOW · PLAN AHEAD

2 NOV — **Toa Payoh West master-plan exhibition · closing day**
HDB HUB · FREE · SELECTED EXHIBITS REMAIN TO MID-2027 · **TODAY IS THE LAST DAY FOR THE FULL DISPLAY** (P5)

18–22 Nov — ***Rafta Rafta* · HuM Theatre, dir. Daisy Irani Subaiah**
ESPLANADE THEATRE STUDIO · **FROM S$57.20** (THE PAGE ALSO SHOWS A S$65 STANDARD PRICE — THE TWO ARE INCONSISTENT ON THE VENUE'S OWN SITE) · 2H15 WITH INTERVAL · **ADMISSION 9+, RECOMMENDED 13+**

20–29 Nov — ★ **Kalaa Utsavam · 25th Indian Festival of Arts**
ESPLANADE · **40 EVENTS, MANY FREE** · *SONGS OF THE BULBUL* FROM S$39.60, BISWA KALYAN RATH FROM S$41.50 · SG CULTURE PASS CREDITS ACCEPTED

21–22 Nov — **Paati's Spice Kitchen · the family pick**
ESPLANADE WHITE ROOM, 11AM AND 4PM · **FROM S$40** FOR ONE ADULT AND ONE CHILD · 40 MIN, NO INTERVAL, FLOOR SEATING · **AGES 6+, SO SQUARELY RIGHT FOR A TWELVE-YEAR-OLD**

3–6 Dec — ★ **Voices · A Festival of Song 2026**
ESPLANADE · **33 PROGRAMMES, EVERY ONE LISTED IS FREE** · MANDO AND XINYAO SINGALONG 4 DEC; MAKE-YOUR-OWN SHAKER KEYCHAIN 3 DEC · **THE BEST VALUE ON THIS PAGE**

4–6 Dec — **Singapore International Marathon · entries closed**
START F1 PIT BUILDING, FINISH NATIONAL STADIUM · **REGISTRATION SHUT 31 OCT; THE LOCAL FULL MARATHON SHOWS SOLD OUT** · A SPECTATOR EVENT NOW; FLEXIBLE-ENTRY HOLDERS MAY CANCEL TO 27 NOV FOR AN 80 PER CENT REFUND

JAPAN & THE REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

4–8 Nov — **Art Week Tokyo 2026 · with Art Basel**
56 VENUES · THE FREE SHUTTLE MAKES IT WORKABLE WITH A CHILD · **NO PASS PRICE OR ON-SALE STATUS IS PUBLISHED** · OPENS THREE DAYS AFTER THIS ISSUE

8–22 Nov — **Kyushu Basho, Fukuoka · sold out**
THE OFFICIAL TICKETING SITE STATES **"TICKETS ARE SOLD OUT ALL DATES"** AND **NO TICKETS WILL BE SOLD ON THE DAY** · ADVANCE SALES OPENED 19 SEP · LISTED HERE AS THE WARNING, NOT THE BOOKING

29 NOV — **Japan Cup · Group One**
TOKYO RACECOURSE, FUCHU · **ADVANCE ONLINE PURCHASE OF GENERAL ADMISSION IS MANDATORY FOR THIS DATE** · ADMISSION PRICES BEHIND A DETAILS PAGE THAT WOULD NOT LOAD · FAMILY-FRIENDLY, WITH PLAY AREAS

2–25 Dec — ★ **Kabukiza December programme**
GINZA · THREE PARTS DAILY, 11AM, 2.30 AND 6PM; **DARK 9 AND 17 DEC** · **TICKETS ON SALE 10AM JAPAN TIME, SATURDAY 14 NOVEMBER** · PRICES ONLY BY BOX OFFICE · **BUY A SINGLE-ACT SEAT WITH A CHILD**

11–13 Dec — **Tokyo Comic Con 2026 · tenth anniversary**
MAKUHARI MESSE, CHIBA · **3-DAY PASS ¥9,900** WHILE IT LASTS; DAY PRESALE ¥5,500, **UNDER-18S ¥1,000, UNDER-15S ¥500** · NICOLAS CAGE PHOTO ¥34,000, MADS MIKKELSEN ¥29,800 · **ONLY THREE NAMED SELLERS ARE HONOURED**

10–24 Jan — ★ **Hatsu Basho · January Grand Sumo**
RYOGOKU KOKUGIKAN, TOKYO · **ADVANCE SALES OPEN SATURDAY 5 DECEMBER** · THE NEW YEAR TOURNAMENT IS THE MOST SOUGHT-AFTER OF THE THREE TOKYO BASHO AND FREQUENTLY CLEARS ON DAY ONE · **NO PRICE IS PRINTED HERE: THE BAND SITS BEHIND A PAGE THAT WOULD NOT LOAD**

PLANNING NOTES

Two hard dates, both inside six weeks. Kabukiza's December programme opens **10am Japan time, Saturday 14 November**; the January basho opens **Saturday 5 December** and routinely clears that day. Anyone wanting Tokyo in the New Year diarises 5 December.

Sell-out risk is now the Japan story, not availability. Fukuoka is gone on all fifteen days with no door sales; Comic Con's three-day pass sells only until it runs out. Buy from the named official seller: Comic Con states that tickets bought elsewhere are not honoured, and the Japan Cup requires advance online admission.

For a twelve-year-old, ranked. Best: Tokyo Comic Con at **¥500 to ¥1,000**, Voices (free), Paati's Spice Kitchen, the Japan Cup. Workable: Kabukiza on a single-act ticket. **Singapore's two big ticketing sites were both unreadable this weekend**, which is why this agenda leans on the Esplanade and the Repertory Theatre.

SOURCES 1 Every Singapore entry read at the venue's own page on 1 November 2026: esplanade.com, srt.com.sg and singaporeinternationalmarathon.com. 2 Every Japan entry read at its official site: artweektokyo.com, sumo.pia.jp and sumo.or.jp (the Fukuoka sold-out notice and the 5 December on-sale date), japanracing.jp, kabukiweb.net, tokyocomiccon.jp, kageki.hankyu.co.jp and marathon.tokyo. 3 **Corrections.** An aggregator listed Takarazuka's *Elisabeth* in Tokyo from 19 December; Hankyu's own site shows it in Hyogo to 22 November with no Tokyo run, so it is not listed. **Christmas Wonderland is not listed either: five weeks out, the organiser's pages still show 2025.** ZoukOut, Singapore Art Week, the Sapporo Snow Festival and the Tokyo Auto Salon were dropped for the same reason. **Nothing here comes from an aggregator alone.**

THE TABLE · TERUMBU BY ORANG LAUT SG

A displaced Pulau Semakau family is cooking its island food until 26 December

Firdaus Sani's mother runs the kitchen and his aunt the floor at a 24-seat residency above Clarke Quay MRT; the Pulau Bowl is S$15.90.

The most interesting thing to open in Singapore in October is not a restaurant. **Terumbu by Orang Laut SG** is a fixed-term residency — it opened on **23 October** and closes on **26 December** — in a 24-seat room at Chef X, the Far East Organization sandbox that lets home cooks run a full commercial kitchen for a stint. It is the fifteenth tenant. *Terumbu* is Malay for coral reef.[1]

The pedigree is the point. Founder **Firdaus Sani** is a fourth-generation Orang Pulau whose family lived on **Pulau Semakau** until they were moved to the mainland in **1977**; the island is now Singapore's offshore landfill. His **mother runs the kitchen**, his aunt **Rohaini** the floor, and the recipes are his grandmother **Nenek Ninah's**, cooked by feel rather than measurement. Orang Laut SG began in 2020 as an Instagram page documenting displaced island communities; this is its first walk-in cafe.[1]

What to order. The **Pulau Bowl**, **S$15.90**, is rice and vegetables with three dishes: *asam pedas ikan karang*, a sour-hot gravy of reef fish left unnamed because it depends on the day's catch; *sotong hitam*, squid in its own ink; and *sambal udang*. *Bubur lambuk tenggiri*, a mackerel porridge, is **S$11.90** or **S$13.90** — and the kitchen is specific that this is the everyday island version, not the Ramadan one. Under S$20 a head; walk-in; shut Sundays and Mondays.[1]

On taste, **too new to call** — and the reason is instructive: the coverage keeps leading on the small history gallery inside the space rather than on the cooking. Tatler Asia's writer calls the food "*unlike anything else in the city*". Nobody has judged it purely as a restaurant. **Whether it is halal this desk could not establish either way, and will not guess.**[1]

Two more, briefly. **Sakana Hikaru**, 14 Stanley Street, opened on **19 October**: Japanese grilled-fish sets on one-fish-one-pot, each order getting its own rice pot and a morning-made stock. Salmon-belly set **S$25**. **The restaurant names no chef, no owner and no parent group anywhere**, so no pedigree is claimed here. **Walk-in only**, and cooking pots to order is slow for a lunchtime office address.[2]

Tan Ser Seng Herbal Soup has taken a mall unit for the first time in eighty years, at Great World. Founder **Tan Ah Sai** reached Singapore in 1927 and began the business in **1946**, selling turtle soup from a pushcart; the claypot version has been the signature since **1986**.[3]

THE BUZZ · TERUMBU, AND WHAT NOBODY HAS REVIEWED YET

Four openings, one verdict: **too new to call**. **Terumbu** has four write-ups and **no substantial review anywhere**. **Sakana Hikaru** has **no review in Eatbook, SETHLUI, HungryGoWhere, Time Out, Honeycombers, the Michelin guide or 8 Days**. The turtle soup has eighty years of goodwill and **not one notice of the new unit**. **Reddit and Burpple both refused this desk**, so there is no social sentiment here. **A fifth candidate was dropped:** an Italian place listed as an October opening whose own reviews date to **May 2025**.[4]

THE SCEPTIC · TERUMBU IS A RESIDENCY, NOT A RESTAURANT

Two of these four are not restaurant stories. **Terumbu** is a **nine-week pop-up**, and its end date is reported as **26 December by three outlets and 22 December by the mall's own page** — the level of care being taken. And **Sushiro**'s Bukit Panjang Plaza outlet is a **promotion**: a limited menu to **3 November** at **S$2.30 to S$4.90** a plate, one-for-one sushi to **12 November**. The new thing is the postcode.[5]

RESIDENCY TO 26 DEC · WALK-IN ONLY · TOO NEW TO CALL · NOT HALAL-CERTIFIED

And one to diarise: **PS.Cafe Harding** reopens at Dempsey on **Saturday 7 November**, free lawn entry from 2pm. **Prices for the day's three ticketed events are not published.**[6]

SOURCES 1 LittleBigRedDot, 21 October 2026, and Tatler Asia, 23 October, both read at source, for every dish, price, date and quotation and the family history. **Neither answers the halal question, so it is left open.** 2 sakanahikaru.com, read at source 1 November — the opening date, the principle, the S$25 set, the walk-in policy and the absence of any named chef are its own; the à-la-carte prices from F Zine, 1 November. 3 LittleBigRedDot, 30 October, for Great World, the chronology and the Geylang reference prices. 4 Each food title named was checked for a review of each venue on 1 November and carried none. **Reddit and Burpple refused this desk.** The dropped candidate's own review is dated 20 May 2025 at the same address. 5 LittleBigRedDot, 31 October, for the conveyor outlet and its promotion dates. 6 pscafe.com's housewarming page; **the circulating dish prices are F Zine's, not the cafe's.**

THE UNDERCURRENT · TAIWAN'S ADMONISHED

Police orders bar 124,617 Taiwanese from internet banking for five years

Fraud losses fell 28.9 per cent in September. The instrument is an administrative admonition, issued by a police agency without a trial, and about one per cent of appeals succeed.

Taiwan is winning its war on fraud, and it is worth saying so first, because the rest of this is an argument about the price. Reported telecommunications and internet fraud cases fell **13.3 per cent** year on year in September, to **10,775**; losses fell **28.9 per cent**, to **NT$3.94 billion**. In the five months to December 2025, losses came in at **NT$32.77 billion** against **NT$62.93 billion** in the same months of 2024 — a fall of roughly half. November 2025 was the lowest month since the government's dashboard began.[1]

The weapon is the bank account. Since a June 2023 amendment to Taiwan's money-laundering statute, handing your account to someone else without good reason is dealt with not by a court but by a 告誡 — *gàojiè*, an administrative **admonition** issued by a police agency. It is not a conviction; there is no trial and no criminal record. What there is, is a schedule, written into a Ministry of Justice regulation and running **five years** from the day the police issue it.[2]

Read the schedule, because it is the whole argument. For those five years the person may withdraw no more than **NT$10,000 a day** from a cash machine. **Internet banking, telephone banking and linking any payment application are prohibited.** Banks **must refuse** any new account they apply for. Any cryptocurrency account is settled and **closed**, and new ones refused. If they sell online, their collections are capped at **NT$20,000 a day** and **NT$200,000 a month** with a payout delay of **at least twenty days**. A further violation inside the window **restarts the five years**.[2]

In a society with **30.2 million** digital deposit accounts, that is not a restriction on banking. It is a restriction on participation. Taiwan has not criminalised the money mule; it has **de-rated** him, **124,617** times, without a single trial. **3,937** complained or appealed; **about one per cent succeeded.**[3]

> ***A category of citizen that did not exist in June 2023, has no English name, and now numbers more than one in every 170 adults on the island.***

The figure that the government reports, meanwhile, is a different one, and it is falling. The count of **警示帳戶** — *jǐngshì zhànghù*, "alert accounts", frozen on a victim's report — rose from about **64,000** at the end of 2021 to a peak near **154,000** in the third quarter of 2025, and has since come down to **133,328** at the end of June 2026. The regulator made that count a **supervisory indicator** for banks, with a watch list and a summons for chairmen who breach it. The count duly fell.[4]

Three things follow, and they are the argument of this essay. The first is that the metric became the policy. The number that measures the state's success counts *frozen accounts*. **Nobody keeps a count of wrongly frozen accounts.** And while the freeze count falls, the register of *admonished people* keeps accumulating, because an admonition lasts five years and does not expire when a freeze is lifted. Taiwan is reporting the falling number and silently compounding the rising one.[5]

Even the falling number is a floor rather than a count. A banking-institute journal makes the point its own sector would rather not: the 150,000 figure **excludes** "derived" accounts — the same person's accounts elsewhere, restricted by association — and **excludes** accounts banks restrict before any police report. It itemises the customer's cost too: repeat trips to branches, borrowed cash, redirected payments — costs that now "*far exceed*" the old hidden costs of financial inclusion.[6]

SOURCES 1 Criminal Investigation Bureau figures presented by director Chiu Shao-chou on 30 October 2026, as carried by the Central News Agency and United Daily News; TTV News, 19 January 2026, for the 2025 comparison — **its dashboard window runs from August 2024, so the totals are the dashboard's, not an audited year.** 2 Taiwan's Money Laundering Control Act, article 22, and the Ministry of Justice regulation under its sixth paragraph as amended 1 May 2025 — **both read in full on the government's own law database**, where the whole five-year schedule is written. 3 National Police Agency data cited by legislator Wang Hung-wei, *Taipei Times*, 15 May 2026. **This is the essay's most important figure and it is single-sourced; whether it counts people or dispositions could not be confirmed.** 4 Economic Daily News and the Central News Agency, 7 July and 12 August 2026, citing the Financial Supervisory Commission. **Monthly figures disagree by one to two thousand; no third-quarter 2026 figure exists.** 5 This desk's argument on the above. 6 Tsai Pei-ling, *The Taiwan Banker*, November 2025.

The second thing that follows is the stranger one. Harden the account and you make a clean identity scarce; make it scarce and you price it. In January 2024 a Taiwanese passbook sold to a fraud ring for **NT$2,000 to NT$5,000** before the law changed and **NT$20,000 to NT$40,000** after; police later found **NT$50,000 to NT$60,000**, with collectors reselling upstream above **NT$80,000**. By mid-2025 the floor was **NT$50,000** and the ceiling **NT$600,000**, with a clean, controllable account quoted at **NT$400,000 to NT$600,000** — a rise of more than thirtyfold in two years. A clean Taiwanese bank account became worth more than a year of median household saving.[1]

And then the market moved on. The Criminal Investigation Bureau's own assessment, reported on **1 November**, is that rings have largely **stopped buying passbooks** and now simply take accounts: phish a bank credential and a one-time password, then bind payment wallets to a stranger's account. A woman in central Taiwan bought a sewing machine on Facebook in mid-June, was walked through a counterfeit courier site and a counterfeit customer-service chat account, gave up her identity number, birth date, account number and one code — and two days later found **three** separate payment wallets bound to her account with large unexplained flows through it.[2]

So the five-year penalty is calibrated for a crime the market has already left behind, and its subjects are increasingly people who sold nothing. The cases are documentary. A man surnamed **Chén** listed spare baseball tickets in a social-media group, gave a buyer his account number, grew suspicious and stopped replying; the ring used the account for a three-party fraud instead, other buyers paid and reported it, and his account was flagged **the same day** — up to **NT$600,000** frozen, including his living costs and student-loan repayments, with his other accounts restricted by association. His lawyer puts unfreezing at **one to two weeks at best and one to two years at worst**, depending on when the criminal case ends. He says tellers questioned every counter withdrawal as if he were a suspect.[3]

Worse, and more revealing: in July 2025 the **Changhua Family Support Center** found it could not pay subsidies to some of the children in its care, because family members had handed the children's accounts to fraud rings. Its director said the centre had been seeing child accounts flagged **every month**. In one household an aunt gave the accounts of **three** children to a ring; in another a parent doing piecework was scammed. Families now collect cash monthly, with social workers delivering in person where the carer cannot travel. Prosecutors warned that a child who knowingly lets a parent use their account could themselves be an accomplice.[4]

Four thousand seven hundred people have signed a petition asking the state for the right to refuse incoming money. Not to send it. To refuse it.

Which is the third thing, and the clearest signal of what this has done to ordinary Taiwanese life. An anonymous citizen posted on a social network and then filed a proposal on the government's own public-policy platform for a **收款人入帳同意機制** — a recipient's consent-to-credit mechanism, a **right to refuse payment**. The design is modest: optional, applying only to a first transfer from a stranger, with the recipient notified and able to decline, "*like a registered letter*". The stated reason is that with nearly 150,000 accounts frozen, a deposit of **one New Taiwan dollar** can trigger alert status, and unfreezing can take up to two years. It had **more than 4,700** endorsements against a 5,000 threshold.[5]

In Taichung a councillor put the inverted crime on the record in December 2025. A fraud victim had been instructed to send **NT$100** to each of **53** accounts as a "membership fee". Police froze **all fifty-three**. One belonged to a biotechnology company, which could not take customer payments or pay salaries and faced a credit crisis; peers told it a fraud alert could take **six months** to lift. Five of the 53 were cleared; the rest were referred to the holders' own precincts.[6]

NT$600,000

THE 2025 CEILING PRICE FOR A CLEAN, CONTROLLABLE TAIWANESE BANK ACCOUNT, AGAINST NT$2,000–5,000 BEFORE THE 2023 LAW — A RISE OF MORE THAN THIRTYFOLD[1]

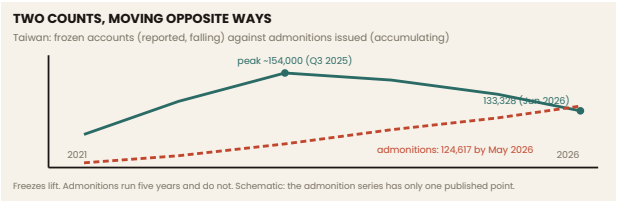
SOURCES 1 Liberty Times, 10 January 2024, and TVBS, 2 June 2025, both read at source; the prices are attributed in both to police and to unnamed informed sources, not to official statistics, and **no 2026 price data could be found**. 2 ETtoday, 1 November 2026, read at source, reporting the Criminal Investigation Bureau's assessment and the case in detail. 3 TVBS, 16 December 2025, read at source, including the lawyer's estimate of unfreezing times. 4 Central News Agency, 25 July 2025, read at source, including the Changhua prosecutors' warning. 5 United Daily News, 9 June 2026, read at source, for the petition, its design and its endorsement count. **Whether it reached the 5,000 threshold could not be established: the platform's own listing returned no data to this desk.** 6 Central News Agency, 8 December 2025, read at source.

South Korea ran this experiment first, and it is worth the detour because it shows both what the remedy is and how little a remedy on paper is worth. Korea's instant payment-suspension regime against voice phishing produced an inverted crime of its own, **통장협박** — "passbook blackmail": a ring sends a small sum into a small business's publicly listed account, files a false report, the account is frozen, and then they demand money to withdraw the report.[1]

The scale, from supervisory data presented to the National Assembly on **19 October 2026**: across Korea's five largest banks, **142,512** accounts were payment-suspended between 2023 and the first half of 2026 after receiving voice-phishing funds, **37,135** of them in the first half of 2026 alone. Suspensions lifted on the holder's objection over the same period: **23,698**. Objections filed rose from **8,880** in 2023 to **13,450** in 2025 — and then **13,301** in six months of 2026, matching a full year in half the time.[1]

Korea's answer was not a better detection model. It was **a clock**. In May 2026 the supervisor issued guidance requiring banks to resolve an objection within **five business days**. Before that there was **no deadline at all**. And here is the part Taiwan should read twice: in July 2026, average processing ran at **18.6 days** at one of the five banks, **16.1** at another, then 9.5, 5.1 and 3.5. Two of the five breached the standard even excluding weekends and holidays. The legislator who obtained the figures called compliance very low, and said that efforts to release innocent accounts quickly matter as much as fast blocking.[1]

Taiwan has built the detection and not the clock. Its fraud-prevention Act speaks of a "*reasonable period*"; the regulation that governs the admonished gives **no length at all** for the suspension during a verification period; and appeals take at least thirty days with roughly a one-per-cent success rate. The forecast writes itself: Taiwan is perhaps eighteen months from a legislature demanding a release clock, and three years from discovering that the banks ignore it.[2]



A *Meridian* original, drawn from the figures on p21. The frozen-account series is quarterly and published; the admonition line is schematic, because only one national total has ever been disclosed.

The counter-case deserves its weight, and the people who make it are named. The Financial Supervisory Commission and the Criminal Investigation Bureau argue, with evidence: it works, on a **48 per cent** fall in losses; the freezes are already unwinding, from 154,000 to 133,328 in nine months, with monthly additions collapsing from two or three thousand to a few hundred after April 2025; precision is improving, through an inter-bank machine-learning programme that roughly **doubled** alert-account precision and let one bank block **1,614** frauds worth over **NT$272 million** in six months; a takedown project with seven platforms has removed about **295,000** fraud-linked accounts; and relief already exists.[3]

That last point is the strongest, and the critics did mis-state the rules. On **27 May 2026** the Bureau said publicly that you do *not* need a non-prosecution order to lift an alert, and listed five grounds — ordinary commercial dispute, three-party fraud, **malicious small-remittance harassment by a ring**, account theft, and administrative error. Bring your chat records to the precinct. And many of the admonished are not innocent: fraud was the most common offence among Taiwanese suspects aged 18 to 23 in 2025, at about **41 per cent**.[4]

So concede the effectiveness. What remains is narrower and sharper, and it is the thing worth printing: a five-year deprivation of financial function, set by regulation, imposed by police, with a one-per-cent appeal success rate, **no statutory deadline anywhere for lifting an alert**, and **no published count of the wrongly caught**. The number the state publishes is falling. The number it does not publish is the one this essay is about — and the honest test of the whole apparatus is whether anyone ever counts it.[5]

SOURCES 1 Financial Supervisory Service data obtained by Representative Park Dae-chul and presented at the National Assembly's political affairs committee audit of 19 October 2026, as reported by Digital Times and Polinews the same day, both read at source. **The reports are explicit that not every objection-based release is a blackmail case. Korea is used here strictly as precedent, not as subject: it was No. 150's Undercurrent.** 2 诈欺犯罪危害防制条例 (the Fraud Crime Hazard Prevention Act), and the Ministry of Justice regulation cited on p21, both read in full at source; the forecast is this desk's own and is flagged as a forecast. 3 Central News Agency, 6 August and 30 October 2026, read at source, for the machine-learning results, the single bank's blocked-fraud figures and the platform takedowns; loss figures as on p21. 4 Central News Agency, 27 May 2026, read at source, for the Bureau's five grounds for relief; National Police Agency statistical bulletins of 2026 for the age distribution — **bulletin titles were read, not the underlying tables.** 5 This desk's own conclusion on the sources above. **Searched and not found anywhere: coverage of this mechanism, this register or this five-year schedule by any of the New York Times, the BBC, Reuters, the Financial Times, CNN, the Guardian, Bloomberg, the Economist, the South China Morning Post or Nikkei Asia. Every English-language account of it is Taiwan's own press or one banking trade journal.**

THE LAST WORD

The unstated number

A watchmaker in Saxony launched a watch on Thursday and declined to say what it costs. Within the hour, four publications working from the same embargo had printed four different prices, two of them two thousand euros apart (p10). That is the shape of the whole issue. The document goes out complete in every respect but one, and the blank is filled in by whoever needs a number.

Meta and Microsoft raised sixty-two and a half billion dollars on the same day and told the regulator it was for “general corporate purposes”; Microsoft’s prospectus went out that morning with all ten coupons and maturities blank (p7). Mistral gave away a trillion-parameter model and published no file size, so two strangers measured it instead (p8). Apple priced its best screen at six and a half thousand Singapore dollars and did not say how many pixels it has (p9). Americans spent a hundred and thirteen billion dollars more in September and took home nothing extra (p14). And across eleven thousand twelve-year-olds, the anxiety finding everyone expected did not appear in a single one of four years (p12).

The sharpest case is in Taipei. Taiwan publishes the number of bank accounts it has frozen, and that number is falling: a hundred and fifty-four thousand at the peak, a hundred and thirty-three by the middle of this year. It does not publish the number of people its police have admonished out of internet banking for five years — one legislator put that at a hundred and twenty-four thousand, once, and nobody has confirmed it since. Nor does anyone count the wrongly frozen. Four thousand seven hundred citizens have signed a petition asking for the right to refuse an incoming payment (p21). What a state measures, it manages. What it declines to count is the part you have to go and find.

TWELVE DESKS · ONE WORLD

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SOURCES A note on method. This edition’s load-bearing figures were read where they are published: the United States Bureau of Economic Analysis’s September household accounts, downloaded and text-extracted in full; the Treasury’s own daily par and real yield curves; Meta’s and Microsoft’s prospectuses and Amazon’s results on the Securities and Exchange Commission’s system; Taiwan’s money-laundering statute and the regulation made under it, on the government’s own law database; Singapore’s law ministry and environment agency; five journals at their publishers; two model cards and a code repository; makers’ own storefronts in seven currencies; and the venue or promoter page for every dated event on p19. Figures that are this magazine’s own arithmetic say so where they appear. Where a host refused us — Reddit for the eighteenth issue running, so there is no Reddit sentiment anywhere in this book; also Hodinkee, Head-Fi, Burpple, HardwareZone, Billboard, Metacritic’s music pages, the Singapore Exchange, the Housing Board’s and the environment agency’s own news listings, SISTIC and Reuters — the page says so rather than quietly substituting. Every photograph in this issue was downloaded and looked at before it was captioned.